

Speaker 1 [00:00:00] By the way, I'm going to let you see the recording. Sorry.

Speaker 2 [00:00:05] Yes. It says this meeting is being recorded.

Speaker 1 [00:00:07] Okay, good. Okay, so let's get started. So, hi. Thank you so much for participating in this interview. As I mentioned over text and email, we want to know more about your views on romantic relationships and we believe your experience and perspective would bring much to this project. So before we begin, I know you really went over this, but I just now ask again is all right, if we record this interview and we will only use it for transcription and note taking.

Speaker 2 [00:00:37] Yeah, sure.

Speaker 1 [00:00:38] Okay, so let's begin. How old are you?

Speaker 2 [00:00:43] Uh, sorry. I'm pausing cause it's almost my birthday. I'm [20-25].

Speaker 1 [00:00:47] Happy early birthday or late?

Speaker 2 [00:00:50] Early.

Speaker 1 [00:00:50] Okay. Early. Early birthday. How long have you been with your girlfriend?

Speaker 2 [00:01:00] Close to [6-10] months.

Speaker 1 [00:01:02] Cool. Do you have children?

Speaker 2 [00:01:05] No. Thank God

Speaker 1 [00:01:06]. Who lives in the household?

Speaker 2 [00:01:10] Oh. So we're long distance

Speaker 1 [00:01:13] Mm hmm.

Speaker 2 [00:01:15] So I guess, like me and then her. She's got a dog.

Speaker 1 [00:01:21] Okay. That makes sense. That makes sense. What is your main source of income? And what is your current job?

Speaker 2 [00:01:31] Mine or my girlfriend's?

Speaker 1 [00:01:33] yours.

Speaker 2 [00:01:33] [Occupation]. Okay. I am a [occupation], so my main source of income is my, like, my [occupation] wage. My. Yeah. So? So I guess the way it works is like for the first [1-5] years, [redacted]. But basically I'm a [occupation].

Speaker 1 [00:02:03] Okay, it makes sense like that. Um, how would you like us to address your partner? I know. Like, I would, like, said girlfriend. I just want to make sure, like, that's still what you want us to address.

Speaker 2 [00:02:13] Your girlfriend, partner and significant other anythings fine? Um.

Speaker 1 [00:02:21] Sounds good. Awesome. Okay. Could you tell me about your love story? So, like, maybe. Like how your relationship before all this.

Speaker 2 [00:02:30] I don't know if [Partner's Name] told you anything.

Speaker 1 [00:02:33] Um, not much, honestly.

Speaker 2 [00:02:35] Okay, cool. Do you mind me asking, is this an ethnographic study?

Speaker 1 [00:02:42] No.

Speaker 2 [00:02:43] Okay.

Speaker 1 [00:02:46] Okay, cool.

Speaker 2 [00:02:48] I'm just curious about how much it means, but it's totally fine. Either way, this is just embarrassing for me. Okay, so we met on [Social Media]. But I guess more accurately than that, we met on the fanfiction sharing website [website name]. So. We both had like anonymous fan accounts because you do not want people in real life knowing that you write a fanfiction or being able to find your fanfiction. And so I wrote something and then she read it. And then what you can do is you can go, I'm going to way too much detail, but you can go on someone's account and then look at like what other works they've bookmarked. And so she read. She like, looked at the fanfiction that I had bookmarked and she was like, Oh, these are really good. Anyway, so one about. Okay, so not this previous [Month], but the one before that. So [Month] [Year], she got fired. And so she was in a bad mood. And so she was like, Oh, I should do something to make someone else feel better. And so she messaged me on [Social Media] saying essentially like, Oh, I really liked your fanfic. And also more than that, I really like your bookmarks. They gave me a lot of reading material and I was like, Oh cool. Haha thanks. And we like chat a little bit. And then eventually I was like, Oh, what do you do? And she said, I'm a [occupation]. And so I kind of asked her about that. She was like, Yeah, we have this one [animal] that really hates being sat on. And so what I do is I just sit on this horse and read fan fiction to pass the time.

Speaker 2 [00:04:39] Anyway.

Speaker 2 [00:04:41] That's not the important part. The important part, I guess, is that. This is my first time making an online friend, and so I didn't really know how to handle it. I kind of kept her like an arm's distance for a while. We moved to chatting on [Social Media]. Yeah, it gets worse. So we were on [Social Media] for a bit. And at first I would reply to her once every like [1-5] days because she'd sent me like [30-35] messages in a row about, like, most of our horseshit, because I kept asking her things about [animal]. And then she would reply in, like, great detail. And then I would get freaked out by how many messages there were and then not respond to her for like [1-5] days. But yeah, eventually what happened? In. I want to say like. Should lie for the first time. We ended up catching each other online at the same time. And so we got until like our first proper back and forth conversation and that ended up lasting like [1-5] hours. So from. I want to say like [Time] to [Time] for me. And then after that. I guess we had more of like an established friendship at that point. And so around [Month] we phone called for the first.

Speaker 2 [00:05:59] Time.

Speaker 2 [00:06:01] And then that ended up lasting like it was like an impromptu thing. She was like, Oh, this thing is like better explained over a phone call. And I was like, okay, great, let's do it. Wind up close for [1-5] hours. And so I was like, That was weird. Anyway, and then we ended up calling again. And that one lasted for, I think I want to say [6-10] hours. I just distinctly remember like I was like, okay, I have so much homework to do, but I've got about an hour. And an hour in, I was like, Wow, I should leave to do my homework. And also I really need to pee. But I don't know, It's like she would say. Something, and then I would just have something to say back or I would just want to know more. And so I'd ask her another question which just kept going and going and like I needed to pee by hour one. But I didn't like just every single time I wanted to be like, Give me a sec, I need to go to the bathroom. There was something else I wanted to say or wanted to hear.

Speaker 12 [00:06:57] And so I just held it.

Speaker 2 [00:06:59] For [1-5] more hours. And it was at the end of that, I was like, Oh, that was weird. Probably nothing to worry about though, because like, you know, this is someone with like a very different life experience from me. I forgot to say I was in [State]. She was in [State] at the time. But yeah. Essentially, I was like, that was. It's normal when you don't know someone to suddenly want to. Like, suddenly have a lot of things to talk about, Right, Because you haven't exhausted those topics. At that point, I was like, Maybe I have a mini crush. But again, we were like a few thousand miles apart. And so it just wasn't practical. When a phone calling some more, I don't know, other phone call lengths. Our next one was like [6-10] hours. The one after that was like [10-15] hours. And then like [6-10] hours again. I'm sorry. This is getting long. I'll wrap it up. The point is, around like [Month] or [Month] at this point, I know I have feelings for her, but I'm trying to be normal and chill because during long distance, like. Not generally recommended, even if you're a lesbian. And but we started flirting really hard. And at this point, I don't know. I knew I had pretty strong feelings. And I want to say she was like aggressively hitting on me all the time. And so eventually, like by like [Month], it's extremely obvious that we are into each other. We spend pretty much every day talking. For at least like an hour or two. We say some. Really sappy shit to each other. And eventually I sent her a video of myself playing piano. And she sent me back. A message that included the words, I adore you. And so I was like, okay, no. This is too much. So I called her and I was like, What are we doing? And she's like, What do you think we're doing? And I was.

Speaker 2 [00:09:15] Like, No.

Speaker 2 [00:09:17] Are we dating? And then we ended up deciding to date.

Speaker 1 [00:09:21] Yeah.

Speaker 2 [00:09:23] Yeah. At that point, I'd already planned on visiting her. She was in [State], so I flew over in [Month]. And then I don't know. We've seen each other. A lot of times I want to say maybe like [6-10] times since then, collective number of days we've actually spent in person is probably around like [1-5] months. I don't know. Does that kind of cover it? Was there anything I missed?

Speaker 1 [00:09:57] Well, no leaks and things. That's a really good description. I really appreciate it. That was and I know which.

Speaker 2 [00:10:04] Details to go into.

Speaker 1 [00:10:05] So, yeah, no, I think I think it kind of basically covered it, you know? Yeah. So I'm just, like, reviewing what it says to you. But yeah, I think you covered it really well. So thank you. Very interesting story. I really enjoyed listening to it.

Speaker 2 [00:10:21] So it's a it's kind of a rough one to tell people.

Speaker 2 [00:10:26] It's like this.

Speaker 2 [00:10:28] I don't know. We always start by saying like, oh, we met each other online and people are like, oh, like on dating apps and no.

Speaker 1 [00:10:36] Like, not really came in meeting each other, like, anyway, I think it's fine, you know, but. Yeah. Okay, thank you for that. So next question is like, how would you compare the quality of your relationship compared to that of your friends relationships?

Speaker 2 [00:10:59] Let's see. How? Like heterophobic am I allowed to be?

Speaker 1 [00:11:05] Um. As much as you want, honestly.

Speaker 2 [00:11:13] Okay, cool, Great. So. I don't know. I saw this thing that's like [Social Media] screenshot or something. That was like it was like by a woman. And she was saying, like. Your toes is just watching your friends. End up with shitty men over and over and over again. And I kind of feel that way sometimes. I don't know. I have like maybe one friend who I think has gotten into a relationship where they mutually respected each other and they really liked each other. And you could just tell a straight relationship. By the way, I don't have any friends in queer relationships at the moment. I think my only friend who ever got into a career relationship was [Partner's Name], and they didn't tell me that much about it. So yeah. But. Yeah, I don't know. I think. I think my other friends are kind of having trouble either knowing how to look for compatibility between themselves and partners or knowing how to enforce their boundaries and ask for respect. Or just Finding that a lot of people simply aren't respectful or don't put their needs first. And so in comparison, I feel like. Like with my girlfriend and I. It's just very obvious to anyone who meets us that we do really like each other. We have a lot of fun together and I think we do like. We do kind of put each other first, so. Yeah. I don't know if my friends just have bad luck or if maybe it is just really hard to find someone. Who You. Like that much and who you are that compatible with. Yeah, I don't know. It's rough out there.

Speaker 1 [00:13:15] Yeah. Yeah. Thank you. Yeah. Can I ask, like, how many romantic partners you've had, like, in the past?

Speaker 2 [00:13:25] Oh, just [1-5].

Speaker 1 [00:13:30] Okay. I'm sorry. The next question is going to be how would you compare this to your past relationship? I guess not. So for you, what makes a relationship a high quality relationship or like a low quality relationship? And why would you say so? Hmm.

Speaker 2 [00:13:52] Well, because this is my first relationship I think I have. Not so much now, but especially when we were just starting out. I have a lot of anxiety over like. What are the correct things to feel at the correct time in the correct magnitude like. For a long time, I worried that the amount I liked my girlfriend was bordering on obsession, for example, which, you know, maybe if I'd been in a few more relationships and had gone through that new relationship phase a few more times, that wouldn't have happened. But. In terms of like if I were to look at a friend's relationship and say, is this a quality relationship? I think that the thing I really look for is does your partner really, genuinely like and care about you? Do you two have fun together and. For example, when something is upsetting you. Does your partner.

Speaker 2 [00:14:51] Do

Speaker 2 [00:14:53] Whatever is in their power to. Accommodate or fix it, or either for.

Speaker 2 [00:15:00] You.

Speaker 2 [00:15:01] Because like, for example, I think a lot of people when they get in arguments about something. So, for example, one partner is behaving in a certain way that's making the other partner, for example, feel insecure and then the partner who the issue is being brought up to will get defensive or try to explain why the other person shouldn't feel that way. Um, whereas like. One indicator I think that always kind of. Makes me smile is if someone, instead of reacting defensively like that, goes, Oh, well, I want you to feel good. And so. I'll fix that or I'll talk through it with you. But yeah, I don't want you feeling bad and. Yeah, I think that's something that we, my girlfriend and I really consistently do for each other. But other than that, just, you know, do you enjoy spending time together? Maybe that's a very [20-25] year old answer because we don't live together and we don't really have shared responsibilities yet.

Speaker 1 [00:16:12] Mhm. I see what you're saying. I mean, I hear that you're saying like it's like you're saying like a high quality relationship has a lot to do with like, if your partner is caring and, like, cares a lot about you. So can you tell me more about, like, how one knows if your partner cares for you and cares about you in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:16:40] Yeah, I guess there's there's so many ways to demonstrate care.

Speaker 2 [00:16:46] Like.

Speaker 2 [00:16:55] There some like I guess explicit ones such as I know my girlfriend has a list of things that I said that I have said I like because she doesn't have a great memory for that kind of thing. So if I say like something, you'll write it down.

Speaker 2 [00:17:15] Yeah.

Speaker 2 [00:17:24] She has this thing where like if, for example, she accidentally bumps me, she like, makes a really exaggerated show of like, you know, kissing it better or whatever or like apologizing. But I think that that one's more of a joke. You know. We fight each other to do the dishes a lot. We fight each other to get bills. We try to do things for each other that we know the other will like.

Speaker 2 [00:18:01] So.

Speaker 2 [00:18:06] I'm trying to think of examples. Like, for example, we. Know, the kind of backrub the other person likes. We are long distance, so we end up calling each other for usually at least like [1-5] hours a day. Someone's going to read that and be like, That sounds unhealthy. Trust me, I've thought about it.

Speaker 2 [00:18:40] Yeah.

Speaker 2 [00:18:40] I don't know. I think we generally pick up on the others feeling down and we inquire about it. And one thing that I guess is important to me is it's very difficult for me to. Bring up when. I'm upset. And so she almost like, meet me halfway where if I like, start to try to articulate something that is upsetting me. She'll almost rationalize my or she'll, like, validate my own feelings for me, essentially, before, you know, instead of making me, like, defend myself. So yeah, that's a lot of scattered things, but I think there are things that convince me that, Oh, this person does really care about me. Wants me to be happy. Etc..

Speaker 1 [00:19:33] Yeah. There's a lot of, like, amazing things here. Um. Um. So what what you say, like, your relationship was like, can you give an example of when you were really. I mean, you kind of already have touch on this, but when it was like when you felt cared for and then when was like, a time in a relationship, you felt like at least cared for. Um.

Speaker 2 [00:20:01] So I guess I've got to be for. For. One thing I. Okay, so when I guess I haven't mentioned it, I don't really cry a lot. Like, if you ask any of my friends, they probably can't really remember a time they've seen me cry. Especially within, like, the past [1-5] years. But I cry a lot. Around my girlfriend. Not because she makes me cry, but because. Because she just I don't know, whenever I am upset, she's so compassionate about it that I get emotional about it. So, yeah, like, I don't know, whenever whenever I'm really upset about something and I. Cry with her present. It always feels nice. I try not to abuse that privilege because if I were crying all the time, that would just be no fun. For Feeling not cared for. So when I am upset, this is kind of a theme. A lot of times, I don't know. I have trouble bringing it up. And so if I am upset about something but I haven't verbalized it and she hasn't noticed that I'm upset Anyway, this has happened a few times. That can make me feel like.

Speaker 2 [00:21:28] Neglected, I guess.

Speaker 2 [00:21:31] Or if she isn't really enthusiastic about. Spending time with me. So, for example, if I want a phone, call her. But for some reason it just doesn't happen. Then I can end up feeling down in the dumps about that. But that latter one is just kind of inevitable when you're long distance. So.

Speaker 1 [00:21:56] Yeah, that makes sense. That's understandable. And for you, what is the most I know you really touch on this like a lot, but what is the most important thing for you in a relationship? And like, why would you say so?

Speaker 2 [00:22:07] Hmm.

Speaker 2 [00:22:10] Um.

Speaker 2 [00:22:15] Well, I think my barometer used to be like, this is the first time I've gotten this far in a relationship, Right? So my barometer used to be what, I rather be in this

relationship or out of it, like on a day to day basis for my life. Or if I were dating this person or not. But at this point, I don't know. I think I am invested enough in her life that it doesn't feel like it is just about whether or not I'm having fun anymore. So I don't really know how to answer that question. I. I. I think for a different person it would be a different. Like for each different person, there would be different things that I valued about the relationship. And therefore I would list, as you know, what was keeping me there. Hmm. Yeah. I guess with [Name] specifically, it is that we. You get on like a house on fire. We have very similar senses of humor and we just I mean, we've been dating for [6-10] months and we still call each other every day for like. [1-5] hours on the low end. So it just it feels good to spend time with her. And I think that. I have. Speedrun a lot of character development.

Speaker 2 [00:23:54] In this.

Speaker 2 [00:23:55] Relationship. So yeah. Yeah, I guess it's down to like, I just. I just enjoy being around her.

Speaker 1 [00:24:05] Yeah. All right. Thank you for that. Yeah. It can be hard to differentiate what is most important. And so I appreciate you trying. Yeah, I know. So, like, for you, what is love? I know this is a pretty broad and difficult question, but. Yeah.

Speaker 2 [00:24:26] Actually, I've thought about this in a lot. Okay, so. You know, the two of us are in a Sapphic relationship where the stereotype is you kind of say, I love you like [1-5] days in. But yeah, we did pop the L Word pretty early for her. It was like [1-5] months. For me, it was like [1-5] months. And I think at that point I remember articulating this to her. Like when you just get into a relationship, it the emotions feel. A lot like it kind of feels like you're not in control of yourself, right? At least for me, it felt like obsession. And so I would not call that rush of positive feeling towards someone love. For me, it was. Like when I was ready to use the L word, it was because. Of a sense of commitment. So, you know, at that point I was like, we'll probably date for. At least a year at this point and a sense of investment in. My girlfriend's life. So. You know, if something bad happened to her, it would upset me a lot. I guess for me personally, there is a component of sacrifice. Like how much am I willing to. Put in to make her happy. Or give up so that we can be together.

Speaker 2 [00:26:14] Which. Yeah. Yeah.

Speaker 2 [00:26:20] Um. So I think love is like a combination of like liking someone a lot and then also an added component of. Commitment and investment in that specific person. And oh, I guess one more thing I would add is that the way you feel about that person is not. Something that. Like you wouldn't feel the exact same way about someone else. Because at that point you might just have a crush, right? Yeah. I don't know if that that made sense.

Speaker 1 [00:27:04] No, that makes a lot of sense, actually. That makes a lot of sense. I really liked the way he described it. Actually makes a lot of sense to do. Um. So how. How important? Like, what do you think? How important is love in a relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:27:19] Um. Well, especially in this current one, I would say pretty important because my relationship is in terms of like, you know, what other things the relationship might function for. My relationship is pretty impractical if not for love, because, you know, we live very far apart. We have spent a lot of money just to see each other. You know, we can't reproduce. We are both cis women. And honestly, our life paths don't like our

careers, do not support each other at all. So yeah, in my current relationship, it is definitely being held up by just love.

Speaker 2 [00:28:15] And, you know.

Speaker 2 [00:28:16] Like in terms of physicality, like. I would consider that part of love, the part of liking someone a lot. But, you know, we don't we don't see each other that often. So it's not like we think that often. For a different relationship. I think that relationships can be held up by a lot of things and practicality, for example. You know, your family's getting along really well or having a really stable, like, nuclear family. Or having even like career schedules that really mesh well can also be things that sustain a relationship. But I personally would not get into a relationship where I didn't really, really like the other person. I think.

Speaker 1 [00:29:05] Yeah. That makes sense. That makes sense. And how do you know that your partner loves you? This can be, like, generic or, like, specific to it.

Speaker 2 [00:29:13] What are your specific ways? She's embarrassing. Yeah. I don't know. Is just it. She very obviously expresses it. Um. I don't know if, like, this is, like, obviously, like, a joke where, um. You know, people will be like literally cuddling their partner and then be like, Do you still like me? Would you love me mad as a worm? Whatever. I get the feeling sometimes. And she'll be like, literally, what? Set that off and I'll be like I don't know? For her, I would say she is just very explicitly affectionate.

Speaker 1 [00:30:02] Yeah, it makes sense. Um, and what would you say, like the challenges are in your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:30:12] Well, the biggest one is our long distance. Another is a. The fact that our I don't know, our career paths don't really cross. So, for example, she does horse work. She she pats little ponies and also sometimes makes them do little tricks. And I. And so that's like, for example, right now I'm visiting her in [State]. We are in. Like, I look outside and I see no other buildings and, you know, I'm going to grad school in geophysics. So I don't know. We've talked a little bit about how.

Speaker 2 [00:30:59] How.

Speaker 2 [00:30:59] We're going to end up building a life together and we're not sure if it's possible. So that's always there. But I guess it's a little easier to brush that off when you're [20-25]. And yeah, I'll be stuck in [occupation] for [1-5] years and [Name] is doing like a mentorship right now. So mentorship like an apprenticeship essentially.

Speaker 2 [00:31:20] Uh.

Speaker 2 [00:31:22] So where were stuck in our locations for at least a few years? Other than that. My parents do not know we're dating, but I swear the timing is coincidental. But I literally just came out to them like, an hour ago. So, you know, it's. My family is pretty present in my life, and. Their vision for me is very much to find a tech bro in [Location], get married, settle down here, have [1-5] kids. And so I would say, like up until now, one of the challengers has been sneaking around them essentially. And. Going forward. They don't know we're dating. So I guess parental approval will be something that I. Have to battle. Yeah. Other than. Yeah, I would say those are the things.

Speaker 1 [00:32:44] Yeah, thanks for sharing and I very much relate to you on the like the dating part of like the expectation to date, you know, like a person who's like in high tech and [Location] is very, I don't know, it's just like a big thing now.

Speaker 2 [00:33:02] Like so all this specific but all of us from [Location] go through it.

Speaker 1 [00:33:06] Yeah. No, I'm like, no, I want someone for love, not for money. I don't know. That's my personal opinion. Yeah. No, I totally relate to you on that.

Speaker 2 [00:33:17] Yeah. Our parents want us to end up with very financially stable lives, I guess. And, you know, I don't make a lot of money. She doesn't make a lot of money. And just from a parental perspective, if you want your kid to really be settled in, it's not great.

Speaker 1 [00:33:36] Yeah. Yeah, it is definitely valid. Um, but yeah, no, I think it's an interesting, like universal [Location] thing. Um, how long do you do you and your partner fight?

Speaker 2 [00:33:59] Um, I wouldn't say so. A.Like, usually what'll happen is, like if there is an issue, it will be like one person saying, Hey, when you do this, I don't like it. Or like when you did that, I didn't like that. And then the other person will apologize. And I would say that's as far as we get.

Speaker 1 [00:34:17] So it sounds like you guys are really good at communicating. So like, when what do you say you have had good communication and like, what happened then? Like. Like my specific example, I would say.

Speaker 2 [00:34:36] Well. So I'm definitely worse at it than she is. I would say the first few times I would. Hmm. I don't know. There's like conflict resolution is a type of communication. Right. And I think that's what people usually refer to when they talk about communication. And so, yeah, what I just described kind of is like. For example, there was a period of time where I was making a lot of jokes that were like. Bordering on condescending. And so she said, Hey, when you make this category of joke makes me feel bad about myself, please stop. And I was like, I'm okay. I'm really sorry. And so that's like conflict resolution, right? In terms of. I don't know. I think a lot of other communication is just. Like, how do you differentiate between. Simply talking all the time. And. Communicating with a capital C. Cause. I don't know. Topics like. I guess we have explicitly talked about like, you know, where we see our future going. What we want from our lives. Things we like about each other. And I would say a lot of that happens naturally. There are some things that are harder for us to bring up. Like my girlfriend really hates admitting when she's not doing well mentally. But yeah, I don't know. I would say that other than conflict resolution, most things just kind of come up because we talk so.

Speaker 2 [00:36:20] Much.

Speaker 2 [00:36:22] And it's not so much that we're making sure to. Bring up certain things. It's just.

Speaker 2 [00:36:34] We're just we.

Speaker 2 [00:36:35] Just talk about everything and we're straightforward about.

Speaker 1 [00:36:36] It. So, yeah.

Speaker 2 [00:36:38] I don't know, maybe we have Super bad communication, but I can't really tell if I'm being honest.

Speaker 2 [00:36:44] Um.

Speaker 2 [00:36:45] I think we're.

Speaker 2 [00:36:46] Fine, though.

Speaker 2 [00:36:48] Yeah. I wouldn't say it's something I think about that much.

Speaker 1 [00:36:50] Interesting. Okay. Do you think communication is important but to reduce conflicts and, you know, have a better satisfaction in your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:37:02] Yeah, I think so. Um, I will say I've seen a lot of cases of over communicating, too. I think there is a balance. Of what You should and should not tell a partner. Like, for example, if. Something about my partner is upsetting me. A lot of times I will actually run it through a friend first to kind of sort my own feelings out. And I think that just. It's a good way of like pruning out the more potentially hurtful bits and focusing on what's important. Well, yeah. Other than that, I. I personally am. In an ideal world, I think we would share. Most things that go on in our lives, most things that we want from each other, and most things that we want out of our relationship. But yeah, I don't think I don't think everything needs to be treated like a problem to be talked out. But if you want a problem solved, then you definitely need to bring it up. Sorry, that's a bit long winded. I hope that made sense.

Speaker 1 [00:38:29] Was a very intelligent. I don't know how to explain. It becomes very intelligent. I can tell you. And like, aside from like a lot of, like speaking to each other and I guess communication, like, are there any other ways that like you think are important for maintaining your relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:38:53] For me personally, and I think for [Partner's Name], too. She's brought it up a few times. I. Yeah, this is sort of a theme, but I think it's really important for us to just continually demonstrate that we like each other. The things we like about each other. And yeah, I mean, a lot of people with long distance relationships will say also trust is really important. But honestly, I don't know. For us it's just not really an issue. Yeah. So just continually continually demonstrating that we like each other and putting an effort. So you know, whether that's like just getting the other person something that they like, like a little treat or cooking them dinner or giving them a back massage or watching a show they like. Putting in an effort to make your partner happy.

Speaker 1 [00:39:53] Yeah. Yeah, that makes sense. And would you say that the relationship is good for you? And why?

Speaker 2 [00:40:03] I think so, yeah. Well, this is my first relationship and having to be with someone who, you know, is very emotionally intelligent and cares about my needs. Means that it has been a pretty good experience for me and it's, I think, shown me what I should expect. Other than that, just even if [Partner's Name] and I just stayed friends, I think just having her in my life has. Given me. I don't want to say a lot of perspective, but that's the closest word I can think of. Because we we come from very different

backgrounds and we are good at very different things. And I. I would say that she's almost like an exaggerated version of the values that I wish I embodied more. I didn't touch on this very much at all, but I because I don't really think about it as much as our values become more and more similar. But. Yeah. I think that our. I, I really respect what she stands for as a person. The fact that she will stand up for what she believes in and. I just think that even on a friend level, she's just a good influence on me.

Speaker 1 [00:41:43] Yeah. Because I believe that your relationship changed you. And if so, in what way?

Speaker 2 [00:41:52] Oh, definitely. I mean, before we started dating, I thought that I would probably end up with a man. I actually don't think I'm into men anymore. So yeah, I think that in terms of changing me.

Speaker 2 [00:42:08] Other than.

Speaker 2 [00:42:10] Okay, so as my first relationship. I think this relationship demonstrated to me that I was desirable at all, that I.

Speaker 2 [00:42:18] Was.

Speaker 2 [00:42:20] A, yeah, a viable romantic partner that someone else might want, which was something that I didn't really believe before. And then, like I mentioned, I think that. [Partner's Name] has made me more willing to stand up for myself and for my principles. So I did end up kind of distancing myself from a friend who honestly was really mean to me. What I want to have done before. And. The biggest thing, I think is that it kind of. Like this is not a relationship that I thought I would get into. I do not see myself spending large amounts of time in rural [Location], but it kind of opened the possibility of leading a life other than the one that had been prescribed to me. Sounds really cheesy, but I mean that in like a very literal way, in that I don't have to have kids if I don't want to. I'm not limited to like suburbia for my long term residence. This year alone, I've seen.

Speaker 2 [00:43:33] Like.

Speaker 2 [00:43:34] A dozen states. Whereas the year before that, I had seen one. So. Yeah, I think it just. Kind of demonstrated to me that I. Have a lot more options than I thought I did.

Speaker 1 [00:43:53] That sounds really great. That's awesome. What about [Partner's Name]? Do you think she changed during the relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:44:07] So she tells me she did. But I don't feel like she has. From my perspective, not much, but from the perspective of herself and the people around her, Apparently, yes. I know that she's a lot more affectionate than she thought she could be in a relationship. I. I saw it coming, though, because when we were just friends. I don't know. I pegged her as a simp. Yeah, she's told me that. She started to give people more benefit of the doubt. Because I do that a lot.

Speaker 2 [00:44:46] um.

Speaker 2 [00:44:51] I would hope she's a little nicer to herself. I think she is. But you'd have to ask her.

Speaker 1 [00:45:00] Okay. Sounds good. I will definitely ask her the same question. I ask her the same questions I ask you. So. Yeah. Yeah. You can ask her after the interview, which you answered if you want. Yeah. Um, but. Yeah, um. Now this is like a little bit of a different side, but do you feel safe in the relationship? I mean, I think you really touched on it like a lot, but it's like you feel safe in the relationship and like, why would you say so? Um.

Speaker 2 [00:45:31] Yeah, I do. And I think the main reason is I. Believe that [Partner's Name] has my best interests at heart. And so.

Speaker 2 [00:45:48] Yeah. It's like.

Speaker 2 [00:45:50] It's like on one extreme is like. The rental market where for some reason, if you're doing anything that has to do with like a lease or an apartment, people are just out to fleece you. That's like extreme end of distrust because those people do not have your best interest at heart. And then on the extreme other end is what I think a romantic partner should be, where they or maybe like a parent or the parents.

Speaker 2 [00:46:14] You have.

Speaker 2 [00:46:15] Your mileage may vary. Where. Your happiness is. They hold it in as high regard as their own happiness. And I would say that. I feel like [Partner's Name] is. Very nearly on that end. So. Yeah. Even if, you know, she accidentally said something hurtful. I never believe that she wants to hurt me.

Speaker 1 [00:46:56] Yeah, that's good. Can you think of, like, any like, specific examples of, like, times you have felt safe and in the relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:47:08] Well, there's all the times I've cried.

Speaker 2 [00:47:15] Let's see.

Speaker 2 [00:47:32] So she's she was my first and like, the first person I've had sex with and. She never made me feel embarrassed or incompetent or undesirable, as I kind of. Learn how to even do that. So I guess that would be an example.

Speaker 1 [00:48:02] No, I think that is a good example. Thank you. Yeah. So next I'm going to ask you about partner responsiveness to show you like a you know, like the likert scale, the Likert scale. You know, you probably have seen this. .

Speaker 2 [00:48:18] I don't think so

Speaker 1 [00:48:19] Really? Okay, You really see? You're sure? Okay. You can see the screen, right?

Speaker 2 [00:48:25] Um.

Speaker 1 [00:48:26] No, like, I mean.

Speaker 2 [00:48:28] Oh, okay. There we go. Yeah, there we go.

Speaker 1 [00:48:31] Didn't specify.

Speaker 2 [00:48:33] Oh, the thing. Yeah.

Speaker 1 [00:48:35] I know. You've seen this. Okay, so this isn't like it's gonna get you to know. So I'm going to ask these questions. Like, my partner really usually, really listens to me. I'm going to say, like, what number you think you are on the scale. Okay, So, yeah, my usual is me. Do you think like, what number.

Speaker 2 [00:48:54] I would say a seven

Speaker 1 [00:48:57] Okay. Okay.

Speaker 2 [00:48:58] You mind if I clarify what they mean by listen? Like, as in when we're talking, like, not tuning me out or.

Speaker 1 [00:49:05] Um, I think it's whatever you think. Oh, okay. Yeah, It's like however you perceive the question. But that's what I assumed as well.

Speaker 2 [00:49:19] Oh, yeah. I sound like a seven.

Speaker 1 [00:49:21] Okay. And then why not like a six or eight?

Speaker 2 [00:49:29] Quite honestly, we talk a lot. And so, like, sometimes when we're on the phone, you know, she is on [Social Media] at the same time. I do the same thing back, but it just so happens. As for why less? Because if I. I don't know. She's I think she's like. Developed a very good understanding of what things I'm sensitive about and not sensitive about. And you don't get that kind of understanding without paying attention to the other to the other person. So.

Speaker 1 [00:50:05] Yeah. Yeah, that can really make sense. Thank you for explaining. So next one is my partner is usually usually is responsive to my needs. Yeah.

Speaker 2 [00:50:32] Maybe 7.5. Or is that too many?

Speaker 1 [00:50:36] I think it's okay.

Speaker 2 [00:50:41] Should I say, why not higher? Why not lower?

Speaker 1 [00:50:42] Yes. Can you explain.

Speaker 2 [00:50:45] Why not higher is because, like on the small scale, sometimes what we want will conflict. For example, I want to eat one thing and she wants to eat another thing. And I usually cave a little faster than she does for why it's not lower with things that really matter. Like if I am upset, she does drop everything for that. So.

Speaker 1 [00:51:04] Yeah. Yeah, that makes sense. That makes sense. So next one is how satisfied are you in the relation with your relationship? So I guess I'm completely satisfied. You're satisfied?

Speaker 2 [00:51:19] This one actually, this is a function of long distance. So I can really only put somewhat satisfied because I wish we lived together or I wish we were at least maybe less than 2 hours apart.

Speaker 1 [00:51:38] Yeah. Yeah, that makes sense. Actually. Makes a lot of sense. Sorry. Let me. I'm trying to show you a different one, but I'm trying to figure. Okay. I'm sorry. There's like a it's depending on, like, what? You think I'm on the scale? How would you think about for your satisfaction in relationship?

Speaker 2 [00:52:01] Yeah, I guess. Same along a scale like six.

Speaker 1 [00:52:04] Mm. Yeah.

Speaker 2 [00:52:06] It's expensive, among other things.

Speaker 1 [00:52:09] Yeah. Okay, Well, that makes a lot of sense. Okay, I'm done. I can do something. Oh, wait. Where's the zoom? Oh, my gosh. Oh, I have to stop to. We will see. There we go. Sorry. No, no, I'm not realizing why. Like, Covid teachers were, like, having a hard time. Um, so now we're going to get into, like, a more personal. I don't know if it's, like, personal, like an emotional sense, but it's going to be about sex, basically. So that's why it's more personal. So if it's too sensitive for you to share. Totally. Don't worry. Like.

Speaker 2 [00:52:53] I hold no reservations.

Speaker 1 [00:52:55] Okay. sounds good. I can kinda tell. Based on what, [Partner's Name]? Well, maybe not for you, but, like, what [Partner's Name] said was interesting. Then I was like, yes, that's what that's the kind of kind of thoughts that we want here anyway. Sorry, I'll.

Speaker 2 [00:53:10] It'll Get worse when you talk to her.

Speaker 1 [00:53:11]. I'm so excited. Okay. Okay. Sorry. So these days, how often do you have sex?

Speaker 2 [00:53:20] Huh? Oh, gosh. I mean.

Speaker 1 [00:53:23] When we see each other.

Speaker 2 [00:53:26] I always joke about her getting none because, you know. We're physically like, separated by thousands of miles a lot of the time. Yeah. I don't know from trip the trip, though it varies like this trip. It's been like every other day with. Sometimes we can be together for like [6-10] days and then only have sex like, once or twice. But yeah, so a big component is that we are not near each other. And also a big component is that when we are together, we feel like we should maximize the time. So it's hard to quantify. I'm sorry.

Speaker 2 [00:54:15] Does.

Speaker 2 [00:54:17] I would. If you have to put something down, I would say once every few days when more put together. If you have to put down a general, I would say. It averages out to like [1-5] times a month.

Speaker 1 [00:54:33] Okay. Yeah, that makes sense. That makes sense. And how satisfied would you say are you with your sex life? And why would you say so?

Speaker 2 [00:54:45] I was a pretty satisfied. I'm the one with the higher sex drive. And so I would say we actually have sex a little less than I personally would like. [Partner's Name] is aware of this, but obviously I do not want to have sex if she does not want.

Speaker 2 [00:55:03] To have sex.

Speaker 2 [00:55:08] Yeah. And then in terms of that, I. Like the total number of times we've had sex is not that high for a relationship of this age. And so I would say we're still figuring each other out a little. I don't know if she'd agree, but I feel that way.

Speaker 1 [00:55:32] Okay. Yeah. Yeah. That's interesting. Thank you. Thank you. And thank you for being very honest and open about that.

Speaker 2 [00:55:39] Yeah, no problem. Doesn't bother me.

Speaker 1 [00:55:40] Me. Um. Okay, so we are close to wrapping up. So. So I'm going to, like, summarize. Okay. I'll just summarize what we talked about. Okay. So it seems like you have a very high satisfaction, a really pretty high satisfaction relationship. But the a big constraint is like long distance and the fact that you're having different career paths.

Speaker 2 [00:56:12] Yeah.

Speaker 1 [00:56:14] And you have you talk a lot over the phone even when you're apart. And the biggest constraint to your satisfaction is like the distance in your relationship is that a good summary. Yeah. Let me know.

Speaker 2 [00:56:40] Yeah, I would say. I don't know. Well, we're just we're pretty stereotypical sapphics in that way. Long distance and all over each other.

Speaker 1 [00:56:51] Okay. Oh, no. Okay. Okay. Okay. Sounds good. Okay. So that's actually it. So thank you so much. Now, before you. Before we end, I want to talk to you about how we'll handle the data. As a result, we want to be as ethically transparent as possible, and so we. We want to know which data sharing option maybe you would be more comfortable with. So the first option is that. Transcript. Portions can be shared then of which can be edified to you so that the identified transcript can also be read by other researchers to is if you are bolder. Another option is that the whole transcript will be shared and it'll be removed of sensitive and the identifying details. So it will be anonymized although in this option. There is a very minimal chance that someone who knows you well can piece together the details in the transcript and they are among their colleagues. They believe it is, but no sensitive information will be shared. So these two options, which are you more comfortable with.

Speaker 2 [00:58:08] For anonymization, would that just be like scrubbing names and place names?

Speaker 1 [00:58:14] Yeah.

Speaker 2 [00:58:15] Okay, that's fine.

Speaker 1 [00:58:17] Yeah, sounds good. So option two. Yeah. Yeah. Okay, So let me. Okay. Okay. So. Awesome. Okay. So. So I know you're saying this. Thank you so much again for participating. The study really does. I'm glad. I'm glad you had fun. I had fun too. But would you? So the way that we're. I'm sure you'd like to know about research, but the way we're doing our research is, like through snowball sampling.

Speaker 2 [00:58:56] We don't know what that is.

Speaker 1 [00:58:57] Oh, interesting. Okay, so I know you want me to explain to you, but basically, it's like. It's like. WHY is this so hard to explain, I took a class. Basically, it's when you get like one or two people to, like, interview. And then you ask those people to give you more people to interview and then they get like, you get to interview those people. And like, so like, becomes like, like a snowball, like running down the hill. So you get like, more and more people. Oh, that's cool. Yeah, that's how snowball sampling everything works. Uh huh. So anyways, the question is. Could you? Do you have anyone in your life like you could, like, nominate or like anyone you're close with that would potentially know any additional couples that would be interested in the study? Oh. The part that I'm doing is because we all like different demographics that we're working with and might not be polyamorous couple not couples, polyamorous relationships and. LGBTQ plus couples. And then I also have like one couple that's must be of low and median. Low to median. Oh, my God, What's the word? Like income, but then, like, have been together for [16-20] plus years. That's my. That's like my. The people are saying, basically, if you happen to know anyone of that realm or no one in who might know anyone of that realm. So do you happen to know anyone basically? Is the question.

Speaker 2 [01:00:32] Huh? So we are literally the only queer relationship I know about that's going honestly, I think we are the only relationship I know of that is. Yeah. No. Okay. So I'm it.

Speaker 1 [01:00:47] Uh.

Speaker 2 [01:00:49] I think we qualify as low to medium income, but we have not been together for 20 plus years. So if those are stuck together, that. Yeah. No, I don't think so. Sorry.

Speaker 1 [01:01:03] No, it's till I get okay. Do you happen to know anyone else? Like a close friend or someone who might know other people? Okay, Let me know. That's how and why I reached out to [Name]. I was like, [Name], please help me.

Speaker 2 [01:01:16] Yeah.

Speaker 1 [01:01:17] You. So that's kind of how that happened. Yeah. So yeah, if you happen to know, like, just like something like, you know, you have to be in a relationship, like someone I can reach out to that might know someone else, if that makes sense. Yeah.

Speaker 2 [01:01:31] [Partner's Name] might so.

Speaker 1 [01:01:33] Okay. I'll definitely. [Partner's Name] son't worry. So. Yeah.

Speaker 2 [01:01:37] Okay. Maybe I'll ask [Name]. She's not in a relationship, but She might know someone.

om in virginity. So mind if I just hand off the same call to her?

Speaker 1 [01:10:08] Yeah, that's totally fine. I'm going to.

Speaker 1 [01:10:10] stop the recording and start it again.

Speaker 1 [01:10:12] Too. Yeah, that's what I'm going to do, just so I can differentiate the two. Yeah, well, let me do it now, actually.

[redacted].